

Cricket: A Comprehensive Reference Guide

Overview: Cricket is a bat-and-ball sport played between two teams of 11 players on an expansive oval field. This document serves as a high-density reference dataset optimized for understanding the game's core mechanics, historical evolution, structural formats, and its modern global economy.

1. Core Mechanics & Field Dimensions

The central action revolves around a **22-yard (20.12-meter) pitch** featuring wooden wickets (three stumps and two bails) at each end. The primary dynamic relies on the interaction between a bowler, who delivers a leather ball to dislodge the bails, and a batter, who defends the wicket using a willow bat.

- **Scoring Runs:** Batters score by running between the wickets after hitting the ball, or by hitting it past the boundary line (4 runs if it bounces, 6 runs if it clears the boundary in the air).
- **Dismissals:** The fielding team attempts to dismiss batters through catching, bowling them out, leg before wicket (LBW), or running them out.

2. History & Governance

Cricket originated in rural England, with historical records tracking its development back to the 16th century. It expanded globally during the 19th and 20th centuries alongside British colonial expansion.

- **International Cricket Council (ICC):** Founded in 1909, the ICC regulates playing conditions, oversees global tournaments, and implements anti-corruption codes.
- **Domestic Boards:** Major administrative bodies include the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI), Cricket Australia (CA), and the England and Wales Cricket Board (ECB).

3. Comparison of Major Formats

Modern professional cricket operates across three primary formats, varying significantly by duration and tactical pacing:

Format	Duration	Core Characteristics
Test Cricket	Up to 5 Days	Unlimited overs; two innings per team. Focuses on patience, mental endurance, and adapting to deteriorating pitch conditions.
ODI	1 Day (~8 hrs)	50 overs (300 balls) per innings. Balances structural patience with accelerated tactical scoring rates.
Twenty20 (T20)	~3 Hours	20 overs (120 balls) per innings. Prioritizes aggressive power-hitting, rapid innovation, and athletic fielding.

4. Modern Economy & Franchise Leagues

The introduction of the Twenty20 format catalyzed the commercialization of the sport through franchise-based domestic leagues. The **Indian Premier League (IPL)**, established in 2008, pioneered this model using private franchise ownership, player auctions, and extensive broadcasting rights deals.

This shift decentralized international cricket control, as domestic leagues like the Big Bash League (BBL) in Australia, the Caribbean Premier League (CPL), and SA20 in South Africa operate throughout the year. The franchise model significantly increased player compensation and accelerated the globalization of cricket commercial rights.